The March of the Flag

Sen. Albert J. Beveridge (R-IN) · campaign speech · September 16, 1898 · excerpts

Source: Library of Congress; reprinted in The Meaning of the Times (1908), available via archive.org.

Delivered during the Spanish-American War campaign in Indianapolis, Beveridge's speech is a blunt expression of late-19th-century American imperialism. He argued for permanent U.S. control of Cuba, Puerto Rico, and the Philippines on the grounds of providence, racial superiority, and economic necessity. The speech makes the racial assumptions of expansionists in the 1898 debate impossible to ignore.

Connect: Beveridge's racial framing of 'destiny' echoes O'Sullivan's 'manifest destiny' (Class 16) from 50 years earlier. What continues? What's new about 1890s imperialism?

Key Passages

On destiny

> It is a glorious history our God has bestowed upon his chosen people; a history heroic with faith in our mission and our future; a history of statesmen who flung the boundaries of the Republic out into unexplored lands and savage wildernesses … a history of soldiers who carried the flag across blazing deserts and through the ranks of hostile mountains, even to the gates of sunset.

On the Filipinos

> It has been charged that our conduct of the war has been cruel. Senators, it has been the reverse. … We must remember that we are dealing with Orientals … with Malays instructed by Spaniards in the latter's worst estate.

On markets

> Today, we are raising more than we can consume. Today, we are making more than we can use. Therefore we must find new markets for our produce, new occupation for our capital, new work for our labor.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. LEQ Thesis (1 pt): Write a defensible thesis arguing whether U.S. imperialism after 1898 represented a continuity with — or a break from — earlier American expansion.

2. Identify the THREE distinct justifications Beveridge offers and rank them by force of argument.

3. How might an Anti-Imperialist League member (e.g., Mark Twain) have rebutted each?